

SUBJECTS

Donna Tartt's first novel, "The Secret History," the story of a group of classics students at a New England college who become involved in one ritualistic Dionysian murder and another murder to cover their tracks, was a cause celebre way before it was a best seller. Ms. Tartt's agent is Amanda Urban of International Creative Management, one of the most powerful literary representatives; her publisher is Sonny Mehta, head of Alfred A. Knopf, and her editor is Gary Fisketjon — the "Tinker to Evans to Chance" axis in the publishing world.

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PUBLISH DATE

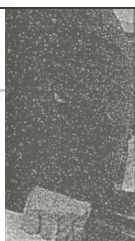
November 16, 1992

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50

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[Books And Literature](#)
[Fisketjon, Gary](#)



Seen/The New York Times chief.

Magazine

als giant is how to mental objectives in ective way and still growth. "It is not an tion," he said. s to perform envi- not just to meet the public expectations, ad what is required rico said. He added a publication like no other one like it. inchild of Igor Gor- ublisher of Geo and er magazines, and t, one of the best- consultants, who art-ups. Mr. Kobak d raised \$400,000 in ne venture.

agreement with Fi- O's initial costs will ll be sent out jointly inance, it will have and the same dem- audited circulation ate card as Corpo- how to advertisers. ee office space and ite Finance's circu- ling teams.

the ECO team with a et their product to a up that is their ideal it gives us access to ertisers that some- business magazines on't," Mr. McIntyre

the publisher, said ertisers were being hat it was too early ECO expects to put 1993, publish no less s 1994 and then be- No decisions have t when ECO might Corporate Finance.

er break from much g. the executives y written, readable going to speak Eng- nan said. "It's not chnocratese."

was a best seller.

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To top it off, Ms. Tartt was introduced to the high-profile three by Bret Easton Ellis, one of the original brat-pack authors of the 1980's who published several books to a loud chorus of not always favorable attention.

So when word about Ms. Tartt's book, which she worked on for eight years, first started circulating, cynics in the publishing world turned on their doubti meters. Another twenty-something wonder, they snipped.

Skepticism to Applause

Then copies of the novel started getting around, and the skepticism began to subside. Applauding reviews quashed most remaining doubts and several months on a host of best-seller lists established "The Secret History" as a true commercial and critical success.

How the novel became such an all-round triumph is a case of the best of marketing and promotion meeting the best of writing, the complementing of strategy and talent.

Although it sounds self-serving when editors and publicists at Knopf say that the book succeeded on its merits, booksellers and editors of best-seller lists agreed, and many said in interviews, that "The Secret History" kept its best-selling position for months not only because of brilliant marketing but because it was a wonderful piece of fiction praised by critics and through word of mouth.

But the booksellers and people at the publishing house also allow that many worthy books do not achieve the sales and visibility of "The Secret History," and that other factors were put into place that helped to bring Ms. Tartt's book the kind of attention that generates sales.

"We as publishers can only influence events in a limited way," Mr. Mehta said. "To the extent that we were able, we did everything right and nothing wrong."

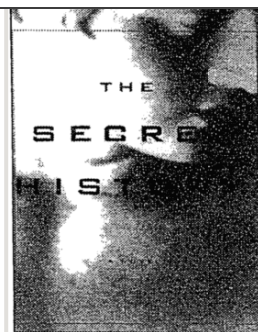
There was also some "gratuitous fortune," as Mr. Mehta put it, or what others would call dumb luck.

A Distinctive Look

Knopf bought the book a few days before the 1991 American Booksellers Convention, which was held that year in New York City. People familiar with the negotiations said the publisher paid about \$450,000 for the book, which was the highest offer Ms. Urban received, and paperback rights were sold for about \$500,000 more to Ivy. In quick order, Alan J. Pakula bought the movie rights.

Since there had been a heated auction for the book, which was then being called "The God of Illusions," it naturally became one of the talked-about titles at the annual gathering of bookstore owners and managers.

"There's no doubt that getting a



The success of Donna Tartt's "Secret History" is a case of marketing and promotion providing a strategy to go with talent.



buzz going at the A.B.A. in New York was important," said Paul Bogaards, Knopf's promotion manager, who orchestrated Ms. Tartt's publicity.

The next step was the look of the book. The book's packaging was carefully created by Knopf's design department "to allow it to be as distinctive as possible," Mr. Mehta said. It is narrower and longer than most novels, and part of the cover, which features a closeup of a classic statue, is printed on an acetate jacket.

A year later, when the booksellers met in Anaheim, Calif., for their annual convention, Knopf had prepared handsome advance readers' editions of the book with its new title, "The Secret History," which it distributed generously. This paperback of the bound galleys foreshadowed the unusual size and cover of the novel. More importantly, it kept talk of the book alive.

"The idea was to get the book to as

the publication date of t give Ms. Tartt maximum ties ai chos fore; h fal big-n aut

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Mr. Mehta's novel that is "enthraling markedly ull" (wh Michiko i descri review in w York only help an auth bright at... article read. Ms. Tartt cuts a ch sophisticated figure at She arrived at one in a ta let jacket with faux leop cuffs and gloves, and lesp the waistcoat punctuatn face, and she steadily quo works that ranged from ' to "The Wizard of Oz."

"We didn't know what like when we bought he Mr. Mehta, "but it certt hurt."

Articles of varying lei with sassy pictures of Ms. ed like a coordinated st September issues of m zines, including Esquire M, Cosmopolitan, Glamou

"In publishing, it is hard to draw the line publicity turns into hype Fisketjon, her editor. "Bu thing that got said o' w the book was in our cetr pinball machine. You hit there once, and then t ju and lights up the machine It's not exactly beyond but it's not necessary s cifically generated."

Hype Machine in Overdrive

But the slew of publicit novel was in the stores i reviewed, caused some about a hype machine i People at Knopf sudde overprotective of Ms. T speaking about how the promoted, everyone invs is careful to say that the publicity was the book it: Mr. Fisketjon describ licity, in general, as havir gun pointed at you." But that no matter how slept or even nasty publicty o basically a no-lose skua book."

"If the book's not tha said, "you figure the publ because the book's prob ing to get anywhere on its least the publicity brngs tice. And when you r you've got a great book, I